

reason, he says, is simple: success.

"It hasn't been any problem so far because, of course, when you succeed at what you're doing, it's easier to work for sure," Joakim says with a smile.

"It's about showing the players that I want to work hard also, because if I show them that I want to work hard and work on small things in a long-term way, they can understand that this is what has to be done," he explains.

He adds that while the aggressive playing style is almost identical for both U-17 and U-20, he tends to experiment more with the older group.

"Some of these players are very young. They are only 14, 15, 16 years old. At those ages, it is more about behaviour. There is still time to develop skills. But with the U-20s, you can go into more tactical things," he says, adding, "It hasn't been too difficult because I also have some good assistant coaches who have been there to assist the other team when I have not been available."

Staying grounded

India's qualification across three women's age categories next year reflects how effective sound mentorship and structure can be. But Joakim says he warns his players not to get too comfortable.

He admits that compared to some of the best teams in Asia, India still has a limited talent pool, something he hopes will improve over the coming decade.

"The most important thing is to understand that we have had to work so hard for this. I've told both batches that when they go back to their home clubs, don't be satisfied being a star in your team," he tells.

"Try to utilise every training session to push yourself harder, to take more actions in both defending and attacking. That is the only way we can change things here."

With the tournaments also serving as qualifiers for their respective World Cups, Joakim plans to commit fully.

"Expectations are that hopefully we will be able to face good opponents in front of the Asian Cup and that we have some good exposures, a good time together," says Joakim.

"We have to progress with both

teams to compete because we don't go in there only to participate. We really want to give it a chance," he adds.

While the U-17 squad is yet to learn its opponents, the senior side faces an imposing task against record winner Japan, as well as Australia and Chinese Taipei. For both teams, qualifying itself marks the end of a long wait. India last appeared in continental age-group competitions two decades ago: the U-17 side exited in the group stage in 2005, while the U-20 team met a similar fate in 2006 in what was then the AFC U-19 Women's Championship.

From urging players to speak up to instilling a winning culture, Joakim has helped create belief in Indian women's football. And in a period of uncertainty for the men's game, his impact suggests that Indian football's revival might well begin with its women.



AFC Under-20 Women's Asian

Cup: April 1-18, 2026, Thailand

AFC Under-17 Women's Asian

Cup: April 30 – May 17, 2026, China

